Comparative Government

Dr Chao-Yo Cheng

Week 9: Communicating

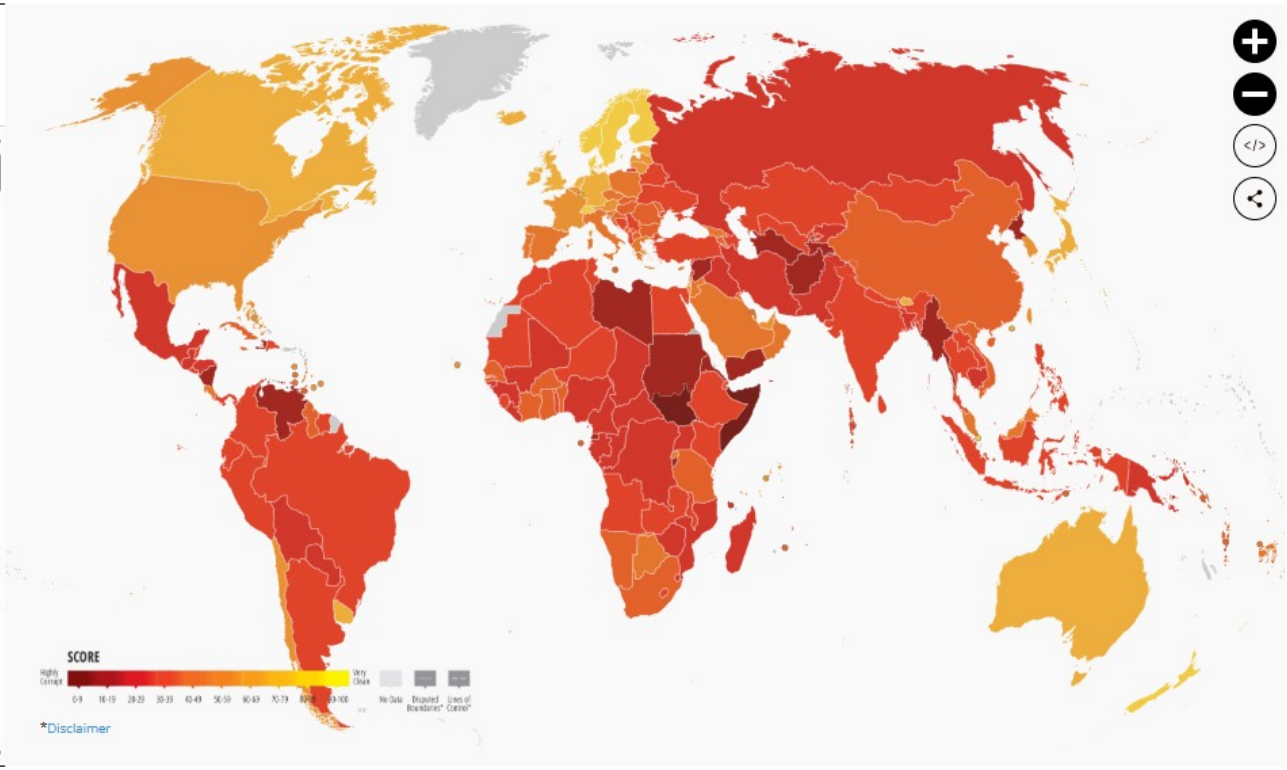
Today's plan

- Quick go-around: Citations for final essay
- Recap from Week 8: Bureaucratic politics and political corruption
  - Sources of corruption
  - Corruption and inequality (Uslaner)
  - Reading exercise: "Corruption and Inefficiency in Local Public Infrastructure"
- Refresher lecture: Political communication in the digital age
  - Media freedom and democracy
  - How social media reshapes political communication
  - Extra: Media censorship and propaganda in authoritarian regimes
  - Reading exercise: "AI and Democracy"

Recap: Political corruption

Search

Score	Country	Rank
89	Denmark	1
88	Finland	2
84	Singapore	3
81	New Zealand	4
81	Norway	4
80	Sweden	6
80	Switzerland	6
78	Luxembourg	8
78	Netherlands	8
77	Germany	10
77	Iceland	10
76	Australia	12
76	Estonia	12
76	Hong Kong	12

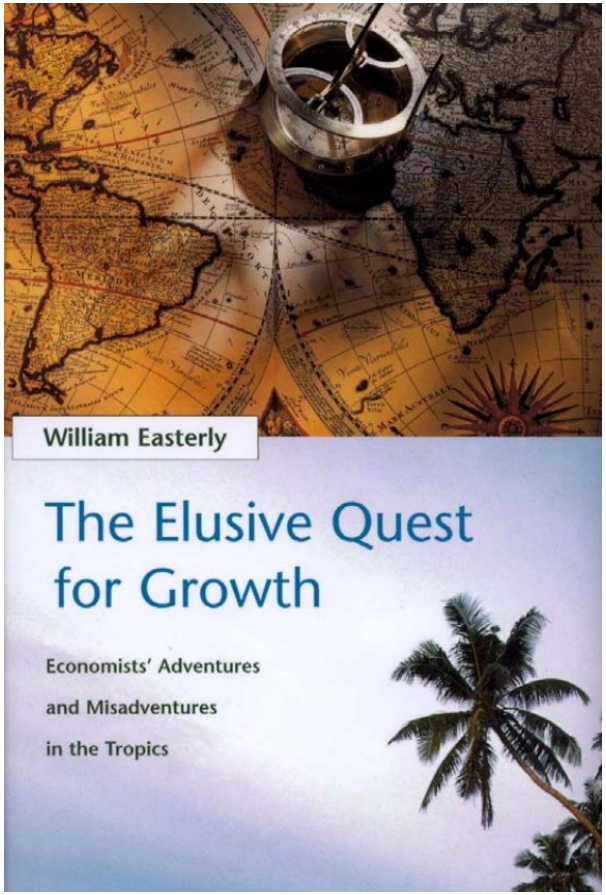


https://www.transparency.org/en/cpi/2025

Measuring corruption

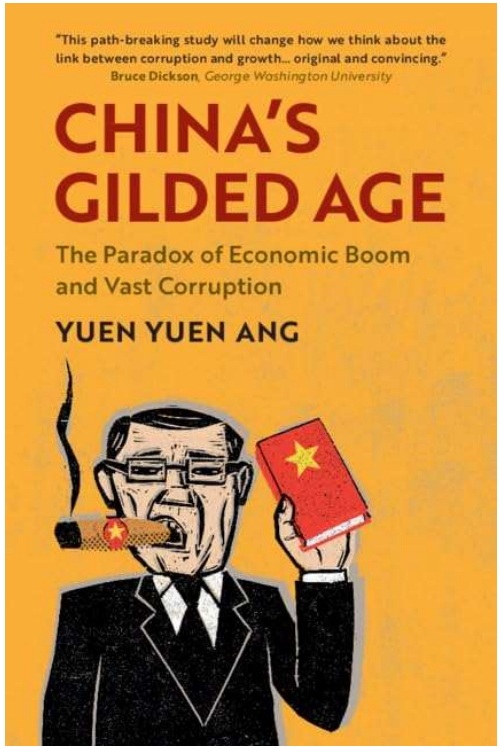
- Using surveys
  - Experts versus citizens?
  - Perceptions versus experiences?
- Using legal investigations and prosecutions (or other official records) – e.g., Yuhua Wang's (Harvard) China's Corruption Investigations Dataset

Types of corruption: Decentralized versus centralized (William Easterly 2001)



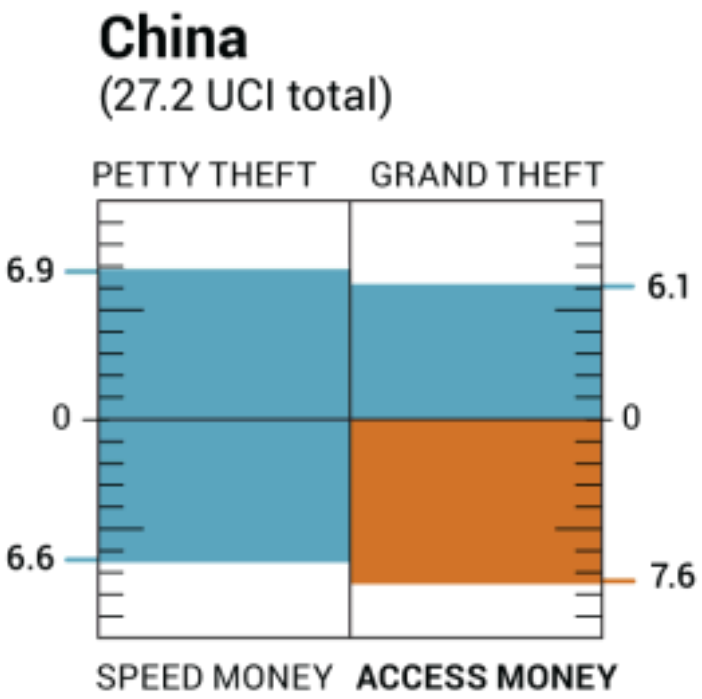
- Under **decentralized** corruption, there are many bribe takers, and their imposition of bribes is not coordinated among them
- Under **centralized** corruption, a government leader organizes all corruption activity in the economy and determines the shares of each official in the ill-gotten proceeds

Types of corruption (Yuen Yuen Ang 2020)



	NON-ELITES	ELITES
INVOLVES THEFT	**Petty theft**	**Grand theft**
INVOLVES EXCHANGES	**Speed money**	**Access money**

- Speed money: Petty bribes paid to low-level bureaucrats to circumvent hurdles or delays
- Access money: High-stakes rewards offered by elite capitalists to powerful officials in exchange for exclusive, lucrative privileges



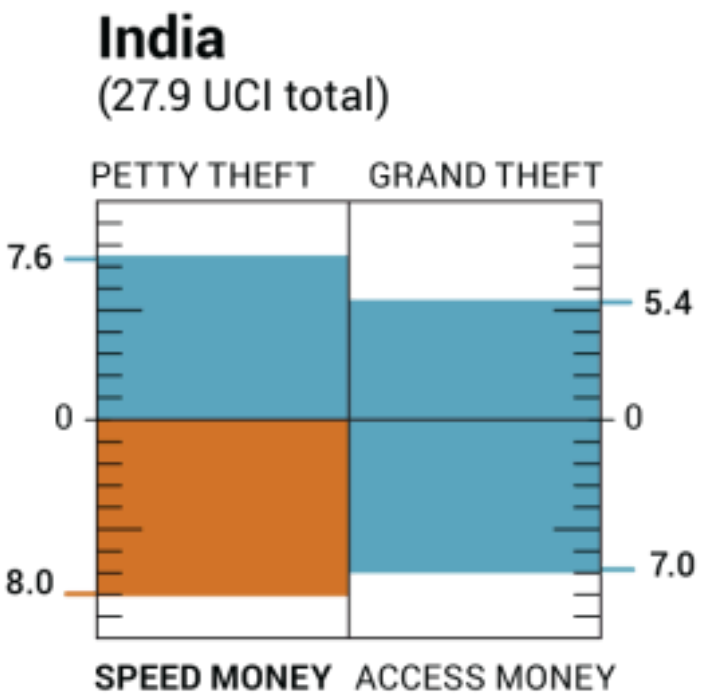


Image © 2020 by Yuen Yuen Ang

“Causes” of corruption (Treisman 2000)

The causes of corruption: a cross-national study

Daniel Treisman*

Department of Political Science, University of California, Los Angeles, 4289 Bunche Hall, Los Angeles, CA 90095-1472, USA

Abstract

Why is corruption — the misuse of public office for private gain — perceived to be more widespread in some countries than others? Different theories associate this with particular historical and cultural traditions, levels of economic development, political institutions, and government policies. This article analyzes several indexes of ‘perceived corruption’ compiled from business risk surveys for the 1980s and 1990s. Six arguments find support. Countries with Protestant traditions, histories of British rule, more developed economies, and (probably) higher imports were less ‘corrupt’. Federal states were more ‘corrupt’. While the current degree of democracy was not significant, long exposure to democracy predicted lower corruption. © 2000 Elsevier Science S.A. All rights reserved.

Keywords: Corruption; Bribery; Government; Federalism; Democracy

JEL classification: D72; D73; H11; H77; K42

- Corruption is **lower** in
  - countries with common law systems
  - Britain and its former colonies
  - countries with a Protestant tradition
  - democratic countries and those with a freer press and more vigorous civic associations
  - more economically developed countries, where populations are more educated and literate, and where the normative separation between "public" and "private" is clearer
  - countries with higher relative salaries in public office
  - countries where political stability is greater

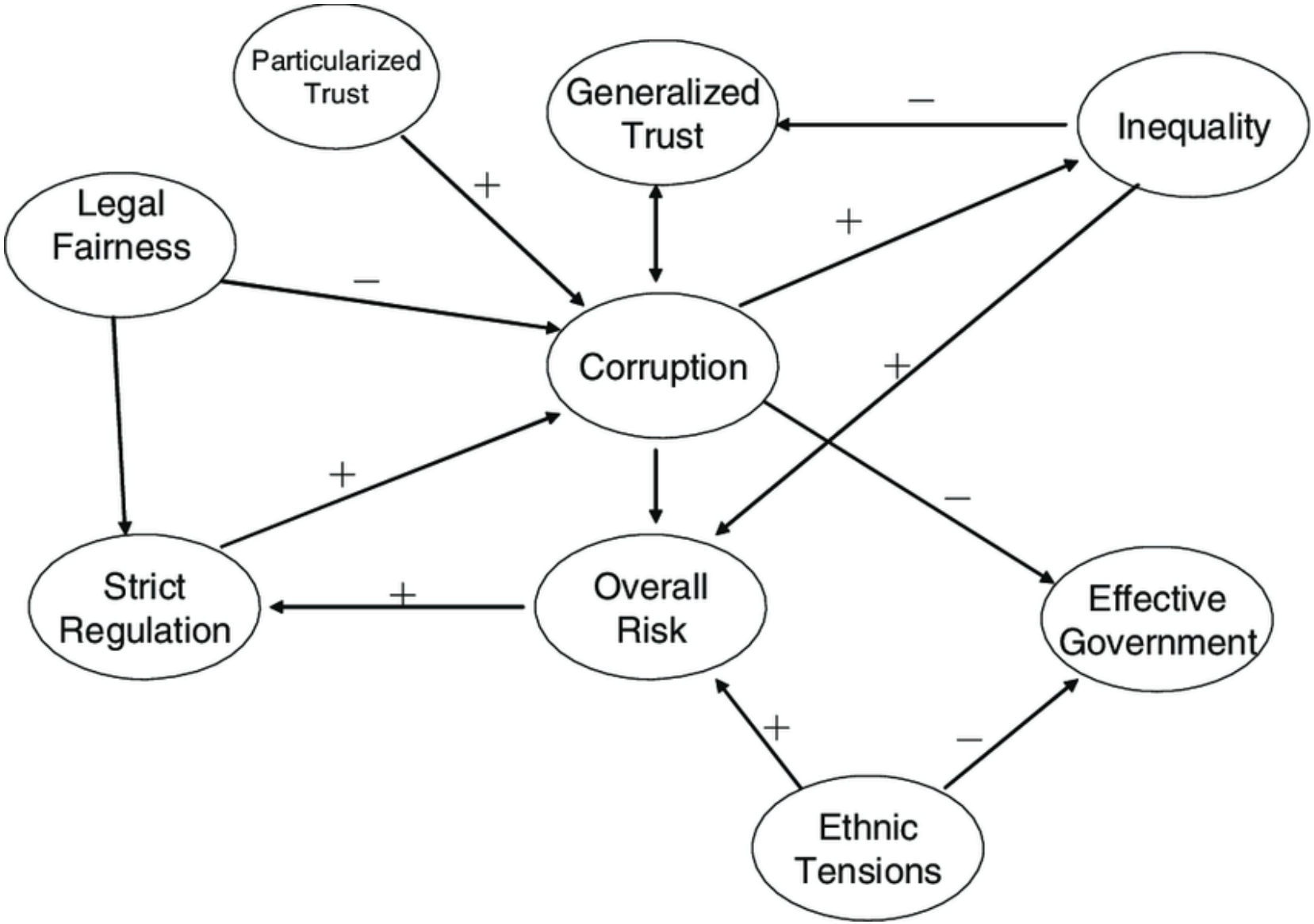
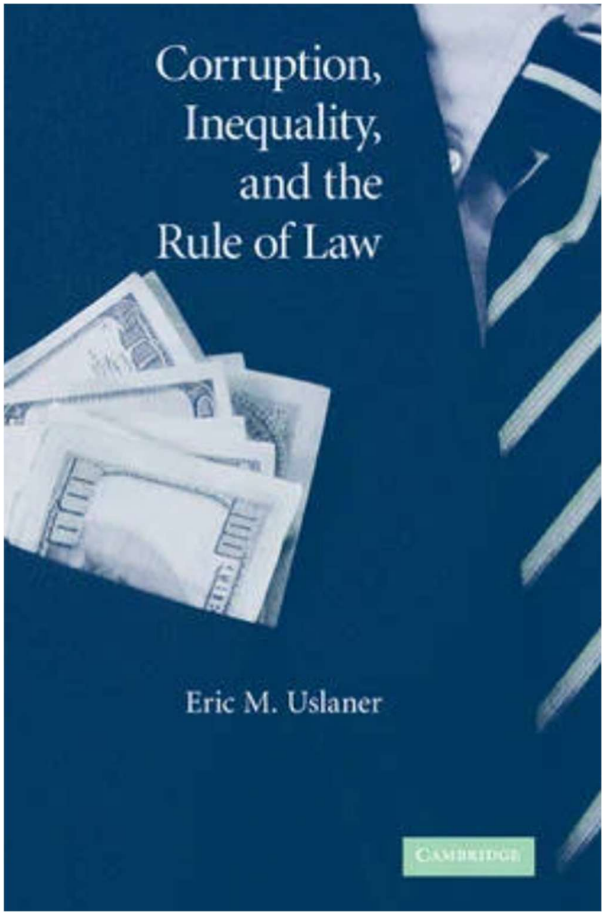
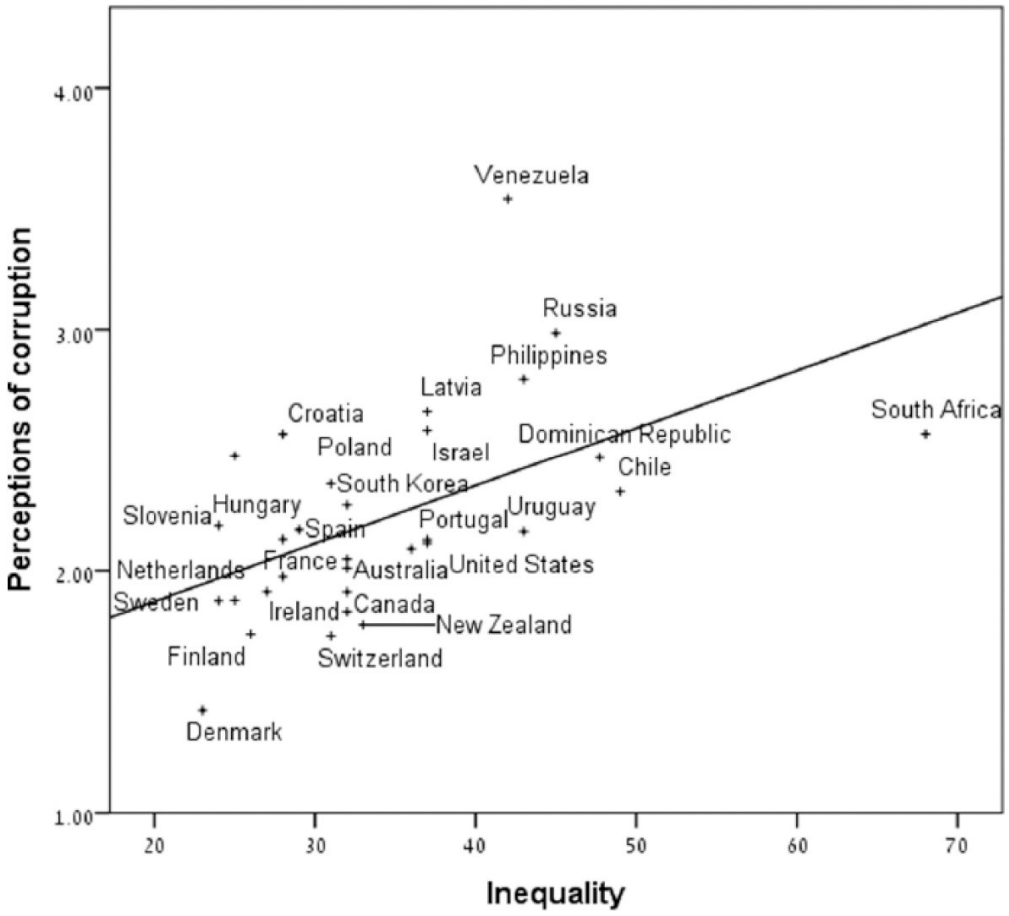

Particularized Trust
Generalized Trust
Inequality
Legal Fairness
Corruption
Strict Regulation
Overall Risk
Effective Government
Ethnic Tensions
+
−
+
−
+
+
−
+
+
−

Table 2
Determinants of perceived corruption[a]

	1996 (TI: WLS)					1997 (TI: WLS)					1998 (TI: WLS)					Early 1980s (BI: OLS)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Common	− 1.93**	0.47	0.85*	0.51	0.51	0.93	0.63*	0.83*	1.01**	1.35	0.65	0.64	0.39	0.43	0.45	1.38	1.23	1.12	1.21*
law system	(0.85)	(0.53)	(0.42)	(0.35)	(0.39)	(0.87)	(0.35)	(0.42)	(0.42)	(1.01)	(1.32)	(0.71)	(0.60)	(0.61)	(0.65)	(1.24)	(0.80)	(0.80)	(0.70)
Former British	− 0.40	− 1.64***	− 1.56***	− 0.90***	− 0.92***	− 3.16***	− 2.00***	− 1.95***	− 2.02***	− 2.05**	− 1.99*	− 1.56**	− 1.25**	− 1.20**	− 1.04	− 2.29*	− 1.39	− 1.22	− 0.96
colony or UK	(0.73)	(0.44)	(0.27)	(0.30)	(0.30)	(1.03)	(0.50)	(0.56)	(0.54)	(0.86)	(1.01)	(0.59)	(0.52)	(0.54)	(0.79)	(1.32)	(0.87)	(0.87)	(0.77)
Never a	− 0.33	− 0.34	− 0.12	− 0.04	− 0.00	− 0.51	0.16	0.05	0.04	− 0.08	− 2.63***	− 0.53	− 0.11	− 0.12	− 0.07	− 0.64	0.65	0.92**	0.82*
colony	(0.71)	(0.50)	(0.36)	(0.23)	(0.25)	(0.72)	(0.41)	(0.40)	(0.36)	(0.51)	(0.86)	(0.43)	(0.37)	(0.39)	(0.34)	(0.75)	(0.48)	(0.45)	(0.45)
Percent	− 0.05***	− 0.03***	− 0.01*	− 0.01**	− 0.01	− 0.05***	− 0.03***	− 0.02***	− 0.02***	− 0.01	− 0.04***	− 0.03***	− 0.03***	− 0.03***	− 0.02**	− 0.03***	− 0.02***	− 0.01	− 0.01
Protestant 1980	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)
Ethnolinguistic	0.03**	0.00	− 0.01*	− 0.01	− 0.00	0.04***	0.01	0.00	0.00	− 0.00	0.00	− 0.01*	− 0.01	− 0.01	− 0.01	0.02	− 0.01	− 0.01	− 0.01
Division	(0.02)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.00)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)
Fuel, metal, and	0.03**	0.01	0.01	0.00	− 0.00	0.04***	0.01**	0.01	0.01	0.00	0.02**	0.01*	0.01	0.01	− 0.00	0.02**	0.03***	0.02***	0.02**
minerals exports	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)
Log GDP		− 4.57***	− 5.14***	− 4.76***	− 4.23***		− 4.72***	− 4.57***	− 4.36***	− 4.87***		− 4.54***	− 4.25***	− 4.16***	− 4.84***		− 4.27***	− 3.83***	− 3.58***
per capita		(0.45)	(0.33)	(0.34)	(0.75)		(0.41)	(0.39)	(0.41)	(1.06)		(0.55)	(0.61)	(0.67)	(1.00)		(0.69)	(0.82)	(0.77)
Federal			1.16***	1.04***	0.76**			0.79***	0.69***	0.77*			0.51*	0.48	0.56**			1.01***	0.67*
			(0.30)	(0.23)	(0.28)			(0.21)	(0.22)	(0.43)			(0.30)	(0.30)	(0.26)			(0.37)	(0.36)
Uninterrupted			− 1.04**	− 1.49***	− 1.51***			− 0.94***	− 0.98**	− 1.06			− 1.02**	− 1.12**	− 1.04			− 1.38***	− 1.54**
democracy 1950–1995			(0.45)	(0.31)	(0.38)			(0.33)	(0.34)	(0.64)			(0.48)	(0.52)	(0.63)			(0.49)	(0.50)
Imports/				− 0.02***	− 0.01**				− 0.01*	− 0.01				− 0.00	− 0.01				− 0.02***
GDP (%)				(0.00)	(0.01)				(0.01)	(0.01)				(0.01)	(0.01)				(0.01)
State					− 0.58**					− 0.40					− 0.52				
intervention					(0.25)					(0.35)					(0.28)				
Government					− 0.03					− 0.17					− 0.13				
wage					(0.23)					(0.34)					(0.32)				
Government					− 0.44					0.44					0.75				
turnover					(0.50)					(0.84)					(1.05)				
Constant	4.35***	22.7***	25.0***	24.2***	24.4***	3.9***	22.9***	22.6***	22.2***	25.7***	6.31***	23.2***	22.0***	21.8***	26.7***	2.89***	18.0***	16.5***	16.28***
	(0.71)	(1.82)	(1.31)	(1.24)	(2.69)	(0.58)	(1.70)	(1.55)	(1.53)	(4.18)	(0.68)	(2.10)	(2.28)	(2.44)	(4.39)	(0.67)	(2.55)	(2.95)	(2.72)
R^2	0.7117	0.9044	0.9421	0.9603	0.9666	0.7870	0.9345	0.9536	0.9585	0.9553	0.5798	0.8783	0.8932	0.8935	0.9289	0.3108	0.6116	0.6532	0.6849
N	47	47	47	45	36	44	44	44	42	34	64	64	64	62	36	64	64	64	64

[a] Log GDP per capita 1990 for 1996, 1997, 1998; log GDP 1980 for 1980s. Fuel, metal and minerals exports = share of total exports, 1993 for 1996, 1997, 1998; 1978 for 1980s. Imports 1994 as percent of GDP 1994 for 1996, 1997, 1998; imports 1980 as percent GDP 1980 for 1980s. White heteroskedasticity corrected standard errors in parentheses. *$P < 0.10$; **$P < 0.05$; ***$P < 0.01$.

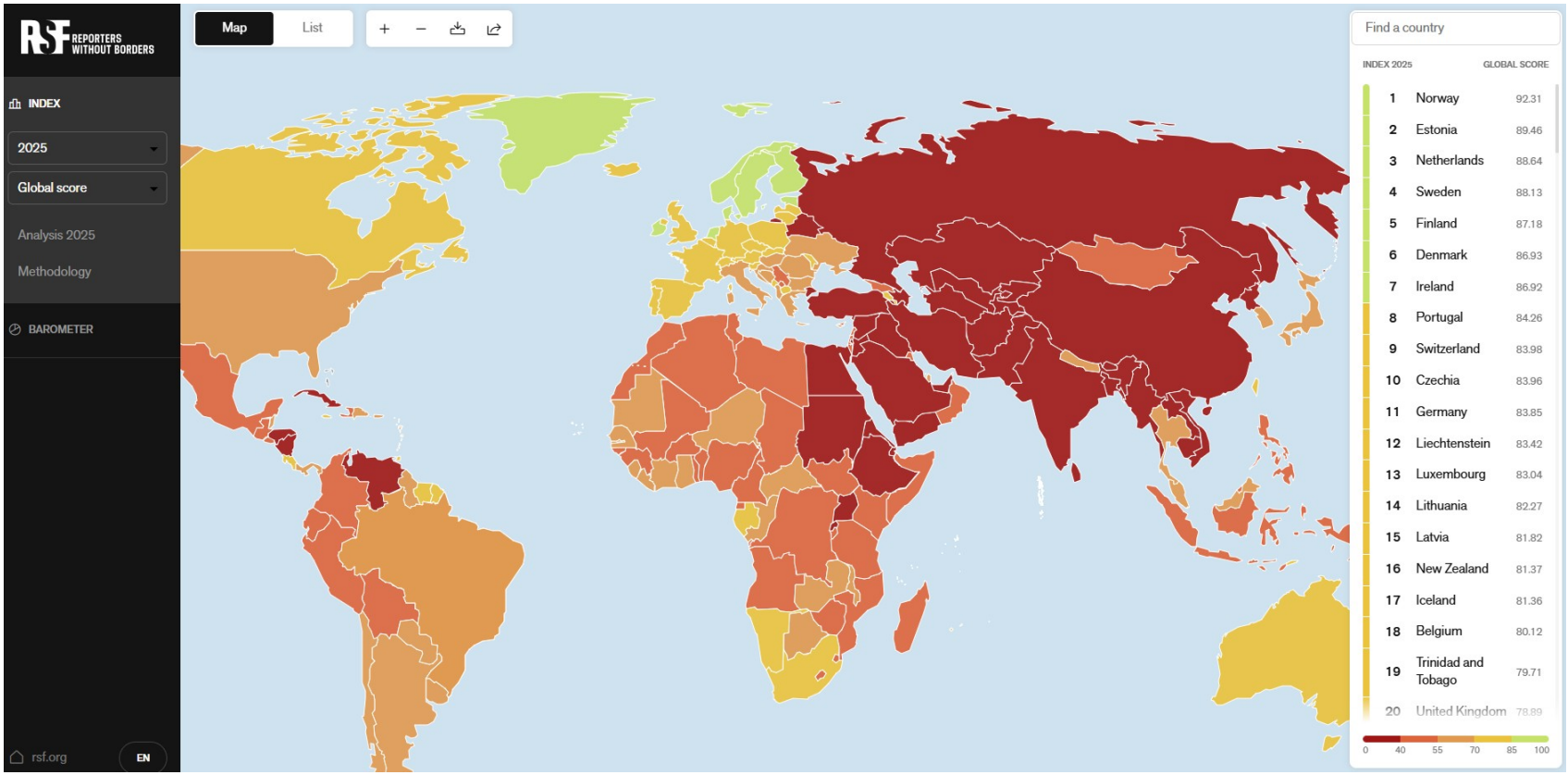

Corruption, Inequality, and the Rule of Law
Eric M. Uslaner
CAMBRIDGE


Perceptions of corruption
4.00
3.00
2.00
1.00
20
30
40
50
60
70
Inequality
Venezuela
Russia
Philippines
Latvia
Croatia
Poland
Israel
Dominican Republic
South Africa
Chile
South Korea
Slovenia
Hungary
Spain
Portugal
Uruguay
Netherlands
France
Australia
United States
Sweden
Ireland
Canada
New Zealand
Finland
Switzerland
Denmark

Refresher lecture: Political communication in the digital age

- Media freedom and democracy
- Democracy and social media
  - Echo chamber and polarization
  - Loss of "local" politics
  - Misinformation and disinformation
- Extra: Media censorship and propaganda in authoritarian regimes
  - Media censorship (King, Pan, and Roberts 2013; Lorentzen 2014)
  - Propaganda (Wedeen 1999; Huang 2015)
- Reading exercise: "AI and Democracy"

World Press Freedom Index 2025 by Reporters Without Borders



https://rsf.org/en/index

How social media drives political polarization through “echo” chambers

- **Ideological sorting**: Platforms provide the infrastructure for politically like-minded individuals to identify and congregate with one another easily
- **Reinforcement loops**: Users are primarily exposed to content that validates their existing worldviews, strengthening their current beliefs rather than challenging them
- **Algorithmic filtering**: Ranking algorithms prioritize engagement, often hiding opposing viewpoints to keep users within a "filter bubble" of familiar information
- **Political isolation**: This environment creates a digital silo that effectively shields citizens from diverse perspectives and healthy democratic dissent

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Your freedom.

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Sign In

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“Is Online Political Communication More Than an Echo Chamber?” (Barberá et al 2015)

- **Context-Dependent Echo Chambers**: Communication resembles an "echo chamber" primarily during political events (e.g., elections, government shutdowns), whereas nonpolitical events (e.g., the Super Bowl) foster a more unified "national conversation"
- **Dynamic Polarization**: Some topics, such as the Newtown shootings, can shift over time, beginning as a broad national discussion before transitioning into a polarized exchange
- **Ideological Asymmetry**: Liberals are more likely than conservatives to engage in cross-ideological information sharing, a trend the authors link to underlying psychological and motivational differences

the british psychological society

the psychologist

Government and politics

Left-wing authoritarianism is real and needs to be taken seriously in political psychology

So says a new study.

01 October 2021

By Emma Young

https://www.bps.org.uk/research-digest/left-wing-authoritarianism-real-and-needs-be-taken-seriously-political-psychology

Decline of local news (and why is it problematic)

Councils in crisis
Regional & local newspapers

This article is more than **2 years old**

Analysis

Collapse of local media leaves us all in the dark

Alexandra Topping

UK's dwindling oversight of local government stems from hollowing out of local news – which may have to find its own fix

- Lawyers raise alarm at struggle to tackle UK local government corruption

Fri 2 Feb 2024 05.00 GMT

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The 'excessive confidentiality' in the Teesworks regeneration scheme found by a review should have been investigated years earlier by a local newspaper, says the reporter who pursued the story. Photograph: Ian Forsyth/Getty Images

The Decline of Local News and Its Effects: New Evidence from Longitudinal Data

Danny Hayes and Jennifer L. Lawless

PDF | PDF PLUS | Abstract | Full Text | Supplemental Material

Abstract

We present the first longitudinal evidence that declining local political news coverage is reducing citizen engagement. Drawing on a content analysis of more than 10,000 stories about US House campaigns in 2010 and 2014, we show that local newspapers over this period published less, and less substantive, political news. We then use panel data from the Cooperative Congressional Election Study to investigate how the news environment influences citizen engagement. Tracking the same individuals over time and simultaneously measuring changes in media content in their communities reveals that reductions in citizens' political knowledge and participation follow declines in coverage about congressional elections. To the extent that the local news environment continues to deteriorate—a likely scenario as the industry continues to struggle—observers' concerns about political engagement in localities across the United States appear very much justified.

All (Mayoral) Politics Is Local?

Sanmay Das, Betsy Sinclair, Steven W. Webster, and Hao Yan

PDF | PDF PLUS | Abstract | Full Text | Supplemental Material

Abstract

One of the defining characteristics of modern politics in the United States is the increasing nationalization of elite- and voter-level behavior. Relying on measures of electoral vote shares, previous research has found evidence indicating a significant amount of state-level nationalization. Using an alternative source of data—the political rhetoric used by mayors, state governors, and members of Congress on Twitter—we examine and compare the amount of between-office nationalization throughout the federal system. We find that gubernatorial rhetoric closely matches that of members of Congress, but that there are substantial differences in the topics and content of mayoral speech. These results suggest that, on average, American mayors have largely remained focused on their local mandate. More broadly, our findings suggest a limit to which American politics has become nationalized—in some cases, all politics remains local.

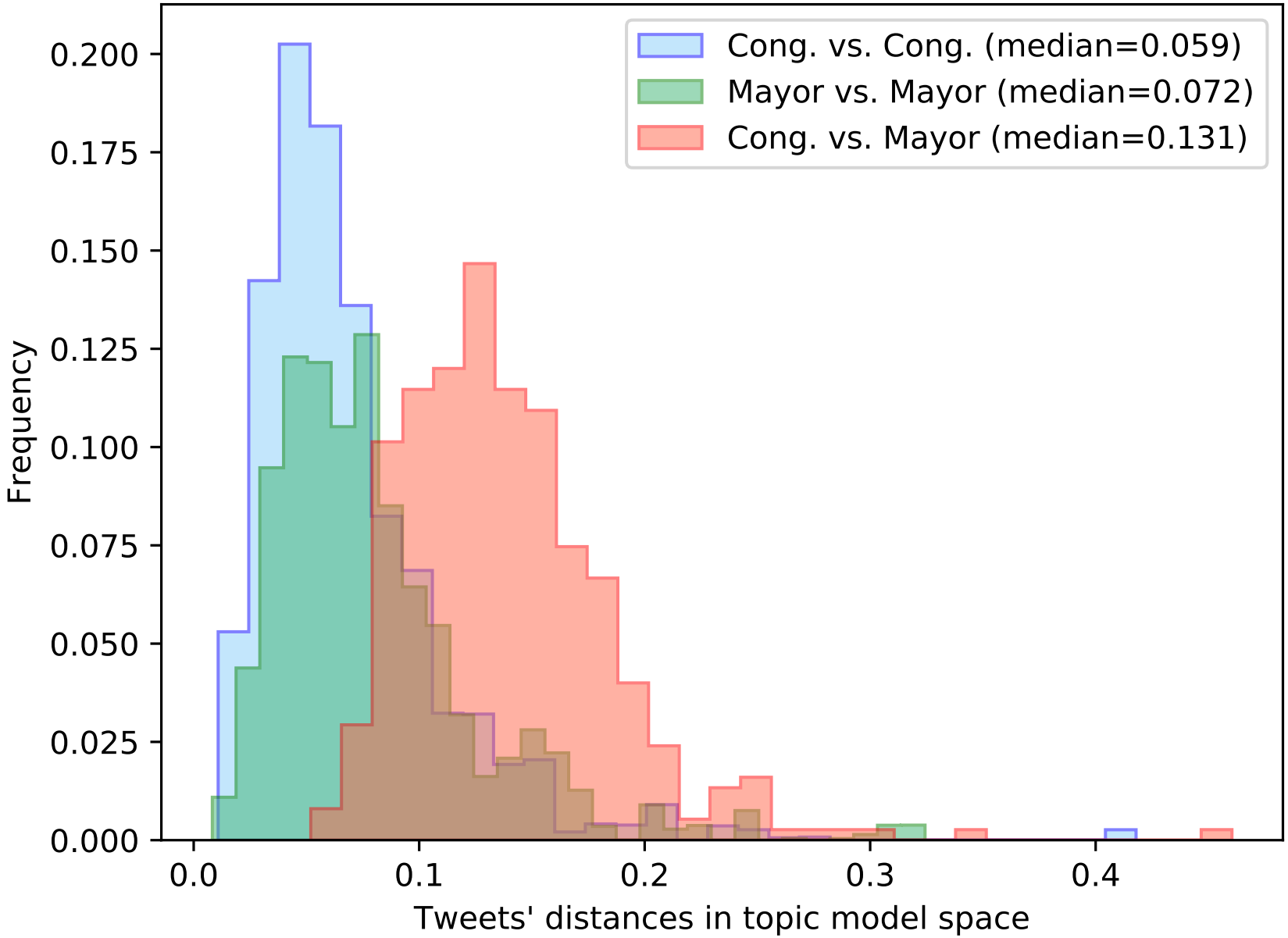


Figure 1: Histogram of topic distances.

Misinformation versus disinformation

- Misinformation is fake news that is created and spread **by mistake**, often by someone who does not realise that it is false
- Disinformation is fake news that is created and spread **deliberately** by someone who knows full well that it is false.

Facebook and Instagram get rid of fact checkers

Liv McMahon, Zoe Kleinman & Courtney Subramanian

BBC News in Glasgow and Washington

https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/cly74mpy8klo

Censorship in authoritarian regimes

American Political Science Review Page 1 of 18 May 2013
doi:10.1017/S0003055413000014

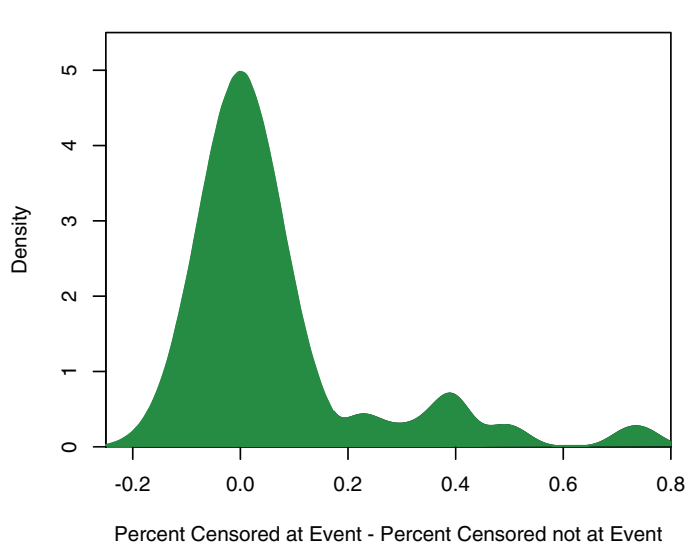
How Censorship in China Allows Government Criticism but Silences Collective Expression

GARY KING *Harvard University*
JENNIFER PAN *Harvard University*
MARGARET E. ROBERTS *Harvard University*

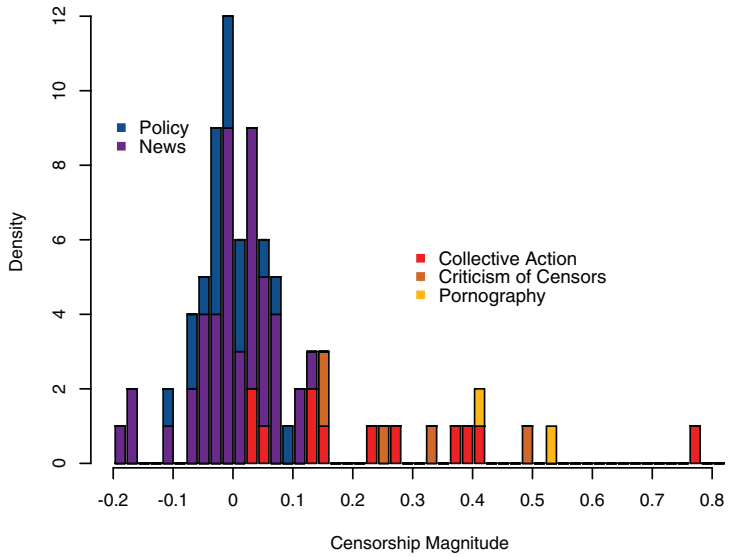
We offer the first large scale, multiple source analysis of the outcome of what may be the most extensive effort to selectively censor human expression ever implemented. To do this, we have devised a system to locate, download, and analyze the content of millions of social media posts originating from nearly 1,400 different social media services all over China before the Chinese government is able to find, evaluate, and censor (i.e., remove from the Internet) the subset they deem objectionable. Using modern computer-assisted text analytic methods that we adapt to and validate in the Chinese language, we compare the substantive content of posts censored to those not censored over time in each of 85 topic areas. Contrary to previous understandings, posts with negative, even vitriolic, criticism of the state, its leaders, and its policies are not more likely to be censored. Instead, we show that the censorship program is aimed at curtailing collective action by silencing comments that represent, reinforce, or spur social mobilization, regardless of content. Censorship is oriented toward attempting to forestall collective activities that are occurring now or may occur in the future—and, as such, seem to clearly expose government intent.

doi:10.1017/S0003055413000014

Figure 3. "Censorship Magnitude," The Percent of Posts Censored Inside a Volume Burst Minus Outside Volume Bursts.



(a) Distribution of Censorship Magnitude

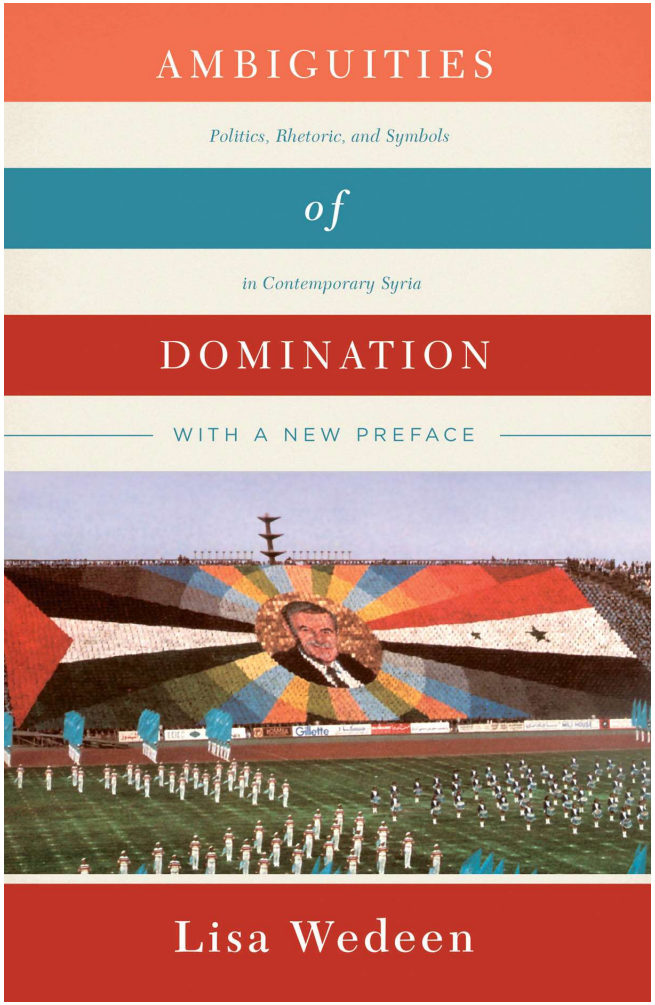


(b) Censorship Magnitude by Event Type

China's Strategic Censorship

Peter Lorentzen University of California, Berkeley

While it is often assumed that authoritarian regimes inevitably fear and restrict media independence, permitting watchdog journalism can actually help such regimes maintain power by improving governance. Yet such a strategy risks facilitating a coordinated uprising if discontent is revealed to be widespread. A formal model shows that under some conditions, a regime optimally permits investigative reporting on lower-level officialdom, adjusting how much reporting is allowed depending on the level of underlying social tensions. This strategy yields many of the benefits of free media without risking overthrow. An extension shows why an increase in uncontrollable information, such as from the Internet, may result in a reduction in media freedom. The model sheds light on important aspects of China's media policy and its evolution and on authoritarian media control more broadly.


AMBIGUITIES
Politics, Rhetoric, and Symbols
of
in Contemporary Syria
DOMINATION
WITH A NEW PREFACE
Lisa Wedeen

Propaganda as Signaling

Haifeng Huang

Why do authoritarian governments engage in propaganda when citizens often know that their governments are propagandizing and therefore resist, ignore, or deride the messages? In China, for example, much of the government's official discourse and rhetoric are so obsolete and far-fetched that they have been widely ridiculed[1] and dubbed the Chinese government's "own worst enemy."[2] Some scholars have even argued that Chinese citizens with more exposure to state media reports may, in fact, have less trust in the government, since more official messages make them see more inconsistencies between the propaganda and the reality.[3] Nevertheless, the Chinese government maintains a massive institutional structure and devotes enormous resources on a daily basis for the production of propaganda in the form of state media publications and programs, political education in schools, ideological campaigns, and various kinds of rituals and ceremonies.[4]

Reading exercise: “AI and democracy”

Disinfo black ops
AI (artificial intelligence)

This article is more than **1 month old**

Experts warn of threat to democracy from ‘AI bot swarms’ infesting social media

Misinformation technology could be deployed at scale to disrupt 2028 US presidential election, AI researchers say

Robert Booth *UK technology editor*

Thu 22 Jan 2026 19.00 GMT

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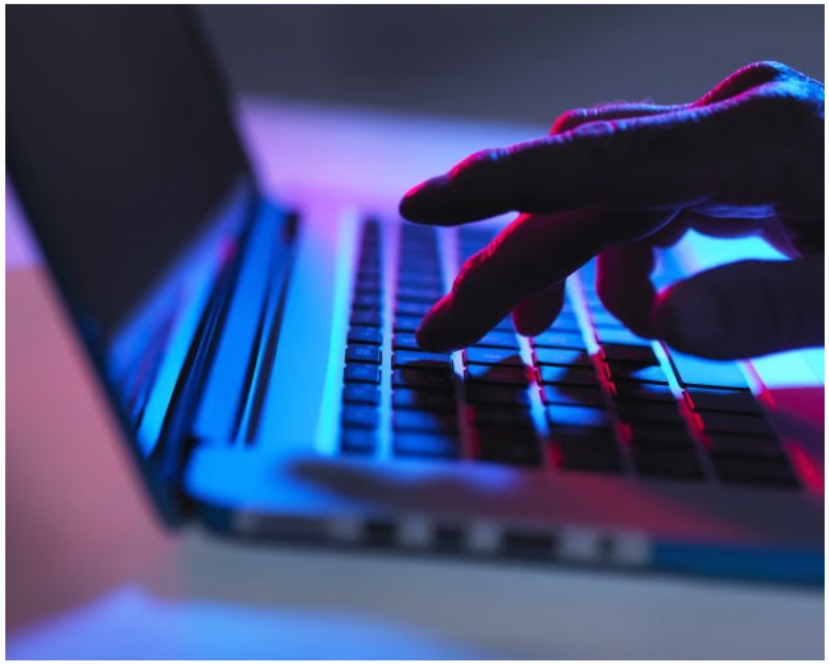

Predictions that AI bot swarms were a threat to democracy weren’t ‘fanciful’, said Michael Wooldridge, professor of the foundations of AI at Oxford University. Photograph: Cultura/REX/Shutterstock

https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2026/jan/22/experts-warn-of-threat-to-democracy-by-ai-bot-swarms-infesting-social-media

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How malicious AI swarms can threaten democracy

The fusion of agentic AI and LLMs marks a new frontier in information warfare

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